

The Western Front

The main front between the opposing German and Allied armies stretched in a huge "S" shape from the English Channel to the Swiss frontier, about 470 miles (760 km).

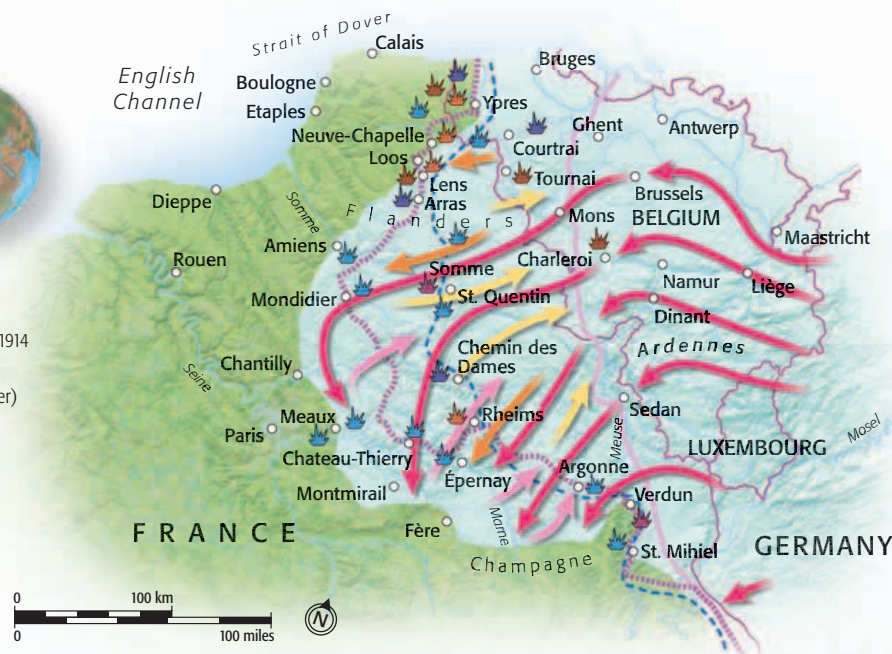


KEY

- █ Farthest extent of German advance, 1914
- German invasion of France and Belgium, 1914
- German retreat, Feb.–Mar. 1917
- Hindenburg line (German defensive barrier)
- German spring offensive, 1918
- Allied counter-attacks, 1918
- Limit of German offensive, Mar.–Jul 1918
- Line at the Armistice, Nov. 11, 1918

Major battles

- | | |
|--|---|
| ✶ 1914 | ✶ 1917 |
| ✶ 1915 | ✶ 1918 |
| ✶ 1916 | |



Chapelle, Ypres, and Loos in 1915, and the Somme in 1916, were hugely costly (57,470 British troops were killed or injured on the first day of battle on the Somme) and failed to break German lines. German attacks on the French city of Verdun throughout 1916 were intended to make France "bled to death." By the time the battle ended in stalemate, there were more than 750,000 French and German casualties.

The other fronts

The Eastern Front was far more fluid. A Russian advance into German East Prussia was halted at Tannenberg in August and the Masurian Lakes in September. German and Austrian

advances into Russia in 1915 were countered by a major Russian offensive into Austria in 1916.

In the Balkans, Serbia repelled an Austrian invasion, but the entry into the war on Germany's side by the Ottoman Empire in November 1914 and Bulgaria in September 1915 tipped the scales. By January, Serbia and its ally Montenegro were overrun, while Romania was defeated the following year. An Allied attempt to force the Ottomans out of the war by invading the Gallipoli peninsula in Turkey failed miserably in 1915. Italy, once a German ally, joined the war in April 1915 on the Allied side, lured by potential territorial gains, but soon became

bogged down in battles with Austrian troops on the Isonzo River in the far northeast of the country.

All the main protagonists except Austria had extensive overseas empires (see pp.346–47). British and French imperial troops occupied German colonies in Africa and the Pacific, the Japanese seizing German colonies in the western Pacific and China. British and Indian troops also invaded



Trench life

Infantrymen wait in a trench near the front line for the order to go over the top. Conditions in the trenches were appalling—muddy, waterlogged, and infested with rats.

Ottoman Mesopotamia (now Iraq), while in 1916 the British incited the Arabs to revolt against Ottoman rule.

At sea, the expected clash between the naval fleets of Britain and Germany never really happened. There were battles in the South Atlantic and at Jutland in the North Sea, but although German U-boats did substantial damage to Allied shipping, the British navy was the stronger force. »

“What a bloodbath... Hell cannot be this **dreadful.**”

ALBERT JOUBAIRE, A FRENCH SOLDIER AT VERDUN, 1916

